

Unit Y309: The Ascendancy of the Ottoman Empire 1453–1606

This theme focuses on the Ascendancy of the Ottoman Empire in the period 1453–1606. Sultans and their political, religious and military systems should be studied within the context of imperial expansion and relations with European powers such as the Papacy, Venice, the Holy Roman Empire, Spain and Portugal. The seeds of decline within the Ottoman governmental system are relevant, but reasons for the subsequent decline of the Ottoman Empire after 1606 will not

be tested. The strands identified below are not to be studied in isolation to each other.

Learners are not expected to demonstrate a detailed understanding of the specification content, except for the named in-depth studies, but are expected to know the main developments and turning points relevant to the theme.

Thematic Study: The Ascendancy of the Ottoman Empire 1453–1606	
Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
Sultans and the organisation of the State	Sultans and their accessions, characters, reputations, absolutism, splendour and ceremony; their successes and weaknesses; administrative and military systems: the merging of the religious and military traditions of the state; personnel, Devshirme; Janissaries; the army; the central political system, the Porte, the Divan, the Grand Vezir; the harem and influence of Sultan's wives; religious administration and justice; integration of religion, politics and law; finances and the economy.
Imperial expansion	Reasons for expansion; expansion in the Balkans including the conquest of Constantinople, Hungary, Vienna; expansion in the Mediterranean; expansion in the Levant, Ottoman control of Levant trade routes, the significance for Portugal, the impact on Europe; the impact of war between the Ottomans and Austrian Habsburgs; the lack of resistance and weaknesses of their enemies.
Consolidation, provincial administration and society in Ottoman vassal states	Principles of Ottoman conquest: occupation, tribute (tax), local vassals, annexation, timar administration; society: enslavement, the rigid class system, local impact of the Devshirme; benefits of peace and stability under Ottoman rule, loss of freedom and status; a meritocratic society, the timar system and feudal sipahis; religion: official recognition of the Orthodox Muslim religion, suppression of Roman Catholicism for the nobility; acceptance and toleration of other differences in belief; provincial administration; the Outer Service, agas, tax, reduced labour services.

The impact of Ottoman expansion on European rulers	Impact on Spain, threats to North African outposts, the western Mediterranean and the coast of Aragon; links with the Moriscos and Barbary corsairs; Ottoman defeat at the battle of Lepanto; the extent of the Ottoman threat to Spain; impact on France: relations with the Ottomans; the Franco-Ottoman alliance and its threat to other European powers; impact on the Holy Roman Empire and the Austrian Habsburgs; including the Battle of Mohacs, the Siege of Vienna (1529) and effects of Ottoman land advance and reasons for Ottoman withdrawal; impact on Venice, Venetian loss of Cyprus; the impact of the battle of Lepanto (1571).
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Depth Studies	Content Learners should be aware of debates surrounding the issues outlined for each in-depth topic:
The Fall of Constantinople 1453	The condition of the Byzantine Empire and authority of its Emperor; the context of Ottoman ambitions in 1453; Mehmed II's qualities; the Janissaries and military strengths of the Ottomans; religious motivation and <i>jihad</i> ; events leading to the fall of the city; the extent of bloodshed and looting; reactions of Europeans and Asian Muslims; the Papal call to crusade and the European response; the significance of the fall of Constantinople; effects on the European economy.
The Battle of Mohacs 1526	The condition of Hungary in 1526, the authority of King Louis and the quality of his army; Ottoman ambitions in the Balkans and Central Europe in 1526; Suleiman the Magnificent, the Janissaries and military strengths of the Ottomans; religious motivation and <i>jihad</i> ; events leading to the Battle; the extent of bloodshed and looting; the reactions of Europeans; the extent of the threat to Habsburg territories and the significance for Ottoman ascendancy; the aftermath and consequences for Hungary.
The Battle of Lepanto 1571	The situation in the eastern Mediterranean after the Siege of Malta (1565); the impact on the Ottoman Empire of the death of Suleiman I in 1566; Ottoman advance into the western Mediterranean and the threat to the Papacy and Venice; aims of the Holy League; the course of the Battle and its significance for the development of naval warfare; reasons for the Ottoman defeat; the battle as a turning point; consequences for the Ottomans; its significance for the ascendancy of the Ottoman Empire.